make it? Was this a way of easing me out? I couldn't get the thought out of my head. *They don't rate me. They want to get rid of me*.

It might have been an overreaction, but that's how I felt. Of course, the first person I spoke to was Eric Harrison and, because of the conversation I had with him, the boss had me back in to explain.

'This isn't about anything else but you getting first-team experience, in a different team, in a different league.'

I'm glad I had that chance to talk to him because it meant I went to Preston in the right frame of mind. When I turned up at their training ground for the first time, I was pretty nervous. I went into the dressing room and all the Preston players were sitting there, as if they'd been waiting for me. I don't know if they were thinking it, or I just imagined they were. *Here's this big-time Charlie from United, and he's a cockney as well*. Either way, it was a really awkward morning. Preston were in Division Three. It was a world away from the life I'd got used to at a club where everything was taken care of for you, where only the best facilities were good enough. At the end of the first training session, I threw my uniform down in the dressing room before taking a shower.

'Not on the floor. You take it home and wash it yourself for tomorrow.'

It didn't bother me. I just wasn't prepared for how things were done at Preston. The manager, Gary Peters, didn't waste any time by way of introductions. On that first day, he got all the players and me together in a circle:

'This is David Beckham. He's joining us for a month from Manchester United. He can play. And he'll take all the free-kicks and all the corners, which means you're off them and you're off them.'

He pointed to the lads who were usually on dead balls and didn't even wait for an answer. What a start. It must have annoyed some of the other players. It would have annoyed me. Things were a bit embarrassing to start with, but once we were working together and got to know each other, I had a great time with all the lads at Preston.

Amongst the players, David Moyes, who's now the Everton manager, was the top man. He was a center-half, the kind of player who'd throw himself into any tackle possible. Even into some that weren't possible. He'd be shouting, revving people up, and was passionate about winning games. He